

SEVEN CITIES OF MARS
— Book Five —

THE CITY OF PASSAGE

BRIAN KEITH ANDERSON

The City of Passage

The Seven Cities of Mars – Book Five

By

B.K. Anderson

Copyright Page

The City of Passage

Copyright © 2026 by Brian Keith

Anderson

All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or any information storage and retrieval system, without permission in writing from the author.

Published by B.K. Anderson

Printed in the United States of America

Dedication

For all who stood at the edge of change
and chose to step forward.

For those who understood
that every passage asks something of us
before it allows us through.

Epigraph

“A gate is not merely a door between
places.

It is a question asked of the traveler.”

— From the Records of the Passage
Keepers

Also, by B.K. Anderson

The Bog Series

- *She Stirs*
- *She Seeks*
- *She Sows*

The Seven Bogs of Mars

- *The Seven Bogs of Mars*
- *The Bog of Patience*
- *The Bog of Silence*
- *The Bog of Movement*
- *The Bog of Restraint*
- *The Bog of Passage*

- *The Bog of Interconnection*
- *The Bog of Seven Hearts*

The Seven Cities of Mars

- *The City of Enduring Light*
- *The City of Silence*
- *The City of Flowing Currents*
- *The City of Restraint*
- *The City of Passage*

A Quiet Reflection

Every life passes through unseen gates.

Some passages are marked by distance.

Others by loss, change, memory, or hope.

Yet the greatest passages are often the
quiet ones—

the moments when we leave behind who
we were

and step toward who we are becoming.

Prologue

I think *Passage* should feel quieter and deeper than *Restraint*—more about transition, trust, and crossing boundaries rather than control. The Keepers/Gate themes can start echoing even in the front matter.

Chapter One

The Quiet Gate

The wind moved softly across the stone terraces beyond the City of Restraint, carrying with it the faint mineral scent of the northern plains. Evening had already begun to gather along the distant ridges, though the last amber light of the sun still rested upon the higher towers behind them. Asa stood alone near the outer gardens where the cultivated growths of the city slowly gave way to untouched ground, and for a long while he simply

listened to the stillness that settled there.

It was not silence as he had once understood it upon Earth, nor even the deep listening quiet he had encountered within the City of Silence. This was something older. A waiting quiet. A stillness that seemed to stand just beyond hearing, as though the land itself held breath against the coming dark.

Below the terraces, the bees drifted among the pale flowering vines that climbed the lower stone walls. Their movement remained calm and steady,

though Asa had begun to notice subtle changes within the hive-song during the past several cycles. At times the hum would deepen unexpectedly, producing faint harmonics that seemed almost to linger within the stone beneath his feet. More than once he had caught himself turning toward distant corridors or sealed arches without understanding why. The sensation never arrived with fear. Instead it carried the strange familiarity of remembering something he had never known.

Behind him, soft footsteps crossed the terrace.

“You felt it again,” Saxifraga said quietly.

Asa turned as she approached through the dimming light. The folds of her pale cloak moved gently in the evening wind, and the silver markings along her sleeves reflected the final traces of day. There remained something changed within her since the awakening of the City of Restraint. Though her movements still carried the calm grace he had long

associated with her people, there was now a deeper attentiveness in her gaze, as if she too listened constantly for something approaching from far beyond the visible world.

“I did,” Asa admitted. “Stronger this time.”

Saxifraga stepped beside him and looked outward across the darkening plains. For several moments she did not answer. Asa had learned to respect those silences, for her people did not hurry thought into

speech. Meaning was allowed to settle fully before it was given voice.

“The pathways are stirring,” she said at last.

“The passages?”

She inclined her head slightly.

“They have slept longer than even the cities themselves. Many believed they would never awaken again.”

Asa looked toward the broken horizon where ancient stone markers stood half-buried beneath drifting sands. He had

seen similar formations before during
their journeys between the bogs and
cities, though until now he had thought of
them merely as remnants left behind by
vanished builders. Yet tonight they
seemed different somehow. Not ruins.
Not abandoned. Waiting.

“What wakes them?” he asked.

Saxifraga’s eyes remained fixed upon the
distant markers.

“Movement,” she answered softly.

“Change. The return of resonance

between places that were once
separated.”

The bees shifted below them then, their
hum rising briefly into the evening air.

Asa felt the vibration move faintly
through the terrace stones, and at once a
strange pressure stirred somewhere deep
within his chest. Not pain. Recognition.

He frowned slightly. “I know that sound.”

“You know the feeling of it,” Saxifraga
corrected gently. “The passages were
never opened by machines alone. They
answered living resonance.”

Asa looked toward her. “Like the bogs.”

“In part.”

The wind strengthened briefly, carrying fine dust across the terrace. Far below, lights had begun appearing gradually throughout the lower city levels, glowing softly beneath the transparent mineral domes that covered portions of the ancient streets. The City of Restraint rested peacefully behind them now, balanced once more after generations of stillness and measured silence. Yet Asa sensed no true ending there. The city

itself seemed aware that something farther awaited beyond its restored boundaries.

“The Keepers knew this day would come,” Saxifraga said.

Asa glanced toward her again. “The Gatekeepers?”

“They watched the passages before the cities closed themselves away. Even during the long silence, they remained.”

“Where?”

A faint smile touched her expression
then, though it carried little comfort.

“That question has troubled many races
for ages.”

Before Asa could answer, the bees below
the terrace suddenly lifted together in a
slow turning spiral. Hundreds rose at
once into the cooling air, not in alarm but
with strange deliberate movement. Their
hum deepened again, fuller now,
resonating through stone and metal alike.
Asa felt the vibration beneath his boots.

Then he heard it.

Far beyond the city.

A single low tone.

It came not through the air alone but
through the ground itself — ancient,
distant, and impossibly deep. The sound
lingered for several seconds before fading
slowly back into silence.

Asa stared toward the dark plains.

“What was that?”

Saxifraga’s gaze never moved from the
horizon.

“The first gate,” she said quietly.

“Opening.”